
Use Code 141

Prospectus for Campground and Related Granger-Thye Concessions

National Forests in Florida Ocala National Forest Salt Springs Recreation Area

**U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
Forest Service**



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Previous edition(s) obsolete.

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- “In Depth Design and Maintenance Manual for Vault Toilets” (USDA-Forest Service)

I. Business Opportunity

A. Introduction

This prospectus is issued to solicit applications for a concession campground special use permit located on the National Forests in Florida, Ocala National Forest, Lake George Ranger District. A permit to provide high-quality public service in the operation and maintenance of Government-owned recreation facilities, will be issued.

The permit will include the following developed sites:

- Salt Springs Campground
- Salt Springs Day Use Area

The authorized officer for this business opportunity is the: Forest Supervisor of the National Forests in Florida.

Ivan Green, Forest Supervisor
National Forests in Florida
325 John Knox Road, Suite F-210
Tallahassee, FL 32303-4160

The current permit for this concession expires on December 31, 2025. Over the past three years, this concession has generated the following gross revenues:

<u>Year</u>	<u>Gross Revenue</u>
2022	\$1,626,645.39
2023	\$1,734,132.62
2024	\$1,173,666.21

B. Area Description

Salt Springs Recreation Area is located on the Lake George Ranger District of the Ocala National Forest, located approximately 35 miles east of the city of Ocala via Interstate 75. The recreation area is approximately 60 miles west of Daytona Beach via Interstate 95, and approximately 95 miles north of Orlando. The Ocala National Forest is within a two-hour drive of approximately 7 million people. The recreation area is immediately adjacent to the town of Salt Springs and State Road 19, the major north/south route through the Ocala National Forest.

Salt Springs Recreation Area is the busiest recreation area in the National Forest. The recreational area is located in the Salt Springs Community with a population of approximately 8,000 people. The recreation area includes a spectacular natural mineral spring. The sub-tropical region gives the campground a mixture of pines and palms, with lush greenery and warm temperatures. The spring discharges over 54 million gallons of fresh water each day and is the major attraction drawing thousands of people to the Salt Springs community each year. Visitors to Salt Springs can enjoy a variety of outdoor activities.

The 440,000-acre Ocala National Forest is the southernmost National Forest within the continental United States and is one of the most popular in the region, providing over 2.7 million recreation visitor days of use per year. The Ocala is noted for its broad range of outdoor recreation opportunities, including a wealth of lakes, springs, and streams, which provide excellent fishing, boating, swimming, and other water sports.

Tourists may be most familiar with the Forest's four major recreation areas; Alexander Springs, Juniper Springs, Silver Glen Springs, and Salt Springs. They are located on large, picturesque natural springs, discharging over 200 million gallons of crystal-clear water each day. Combined, these sites can accommodate 1,770 campers and over 1,800 swimmers at one time. These four large and highly developed recreation areas account for the majority of the developed recreation use on the Ocala. Numerous other smaller campgrounds and swimming areas on the Forest offer more intimate, natural, and remote recreation experiences to satisfy a diverse range of user preferences.

In addition to the over 240 miles of hiking, horse, and off-road bicycling trails; the Forest also boasts four wilderness areas for hiking and a designated trail system available for off-highway vehicle use and hunter access.

The climate of the Ocala National Forest (NF) is characterized by a long, warm season and short, cold season. Much of the winter is mild, with daytime temperatures in the 50's. Although short cold snaps may drop temperatures into the 30's and 40's, an occasional warm spell may produce temperatures in the 60's to 70's. Summers are usually hot and humid, with temperatures in the 80's and 90's and frequent thundershowers, especially in the afternoons and evenings. The warm temperatures and abundant annual precipitation produce a subtropical atmosphere within the Forest. The Ocala NF is in close proximity to major Florida tourist destinations such as Disney World in Orlando, St. Augustine, Jacksonville, and Daytona Beach (see Figure 1). The Ocala NF is a favorite vacation spot of northern and international visitors too.

The ecosystems of the Ocala National Forest are diverse and produce a wide range of recreation settings including lush and shady mixed-hardwood hammocks; open and park-like longleaf; slash and loblolly pine sand hills; and the dry and seemingly-barren sand pine/evergreen shrub forest comprising the "Big Scrub."

Florida Counties Surrounding the Ocala National Forest



Figure 1

C. Description of Developed Recreation Sites and Facilities

The following is a description of each developed recreation site included in this prospectus (*see* Appendix 2 of the prospectus).

Salt Springs Recreation Area Complex:

- Campground
- Day Use Area / Salt Springs Swimming Area
- Bear Swamp Trail

The recreational area provides plenty of activities to keep campers occupied, in addition to swimming the springs, campers come to fish, snorkel, hike and boat. Hikers have easy access to the Florida National Scenic Trail. The springs, Lake George and the many surrounding rivers and streams provide opportunities for water activities.



View in Salt Springs Full Hook-up Campground

The campground consists of 162 sites:

- 105 full-service hook-up sites with water, electric and sewer hook-ups.
- Two (2) full-service hook-up sites available as host sites.
- 54 primitive sites (no hook-ups).
- Two (2) bathhouse buildings each with six (6) toilets, six (6) showers, and four (4) lavatories
- One (1) primitive boat ramp
- One (1) waste water lift station
- One (1) trailer dump station
- A multi-use building that is currently being used as storage, employee laundry and bathhouse.



Typical view in Salt Springs Primitive Campground Area



Pavillion and Basketball court near the Full-hookup Campground Area.

Day-Use Area

The Salt Springs Day Use Area is extremely popular with both locals and tourists. The spring is the major attraction, drawing visitors to swim, picnic and sight see.



View of the steps down to the Salt Springs Day Use swimming area.



View of Salt Springs Swimming Area



View of Salt Springs Day Use Area picnic tables.

The day-use area consists of:

- 30 picnic tables, combination of wooden and metal with rubberized coating tables
- One (1) Restroom facility with changing stations
- A swimming area
- One (1) interpretive display
- One (1) concession building
- 140-car capacity parking lot

Support Facilities

The support facilities are:

- Waste water lift station
- Trailer dump station
- Entrance security gate/system
- Campground/day use entrance roads
- Natural surface road
- Play areas
- Bear Swamp Trail: A 1.45-mile walking trail with an 800-foot boardwalk



View of Bear Swamp Trail



View of the entrance of the Bear Swamp Trail.

Trail Summary and Maintenance

An easy walk for hikers of all ages, the Bear Swamp Trail provides a boardwalk through the densest part of the ancient cypress swamp. The 1.45-mile loop starts and ends at the edge of the campground and includes interpretive information along the route.

The Permit Holder will be responsible for maintaining the Bear Swamp Trail. Maintain the clearing width at a minimum of eight (8) feet and the clearing height will be maintained at a minimum of ten (10) feet. Treat and maintain the wooden boardwalks and platforms to minimize mildew formation and other slippery conditions.

D. Government Furnished Property

The Forest Service will provide certain property in conjunction with the concession campground special use permit (*see Appendix 3 of the prospectus*). Included in this inventory are a description, the quantity, and the estimated replacement cost of the applicable property.

E. Government Furnished Supplies

The Forest Service will not furnish any supplies for day-to-day operation of the concession. Government-furnished supplies will be limited to those necessary for programmatic consistency, including:

- Forms to report use and revenue included in **Appendix 5: Sample Use Report- 508c**
- A copy of the Forest Service publications, “Cleaning Recreation Sites,” “In-Depth Design and Maintenance Manual for Vault Toilets,” and “Vault Toilet Pumping Contract Specifications and Guidelines for Preparing Contracts.”
- A copy of “Recreation Opportunity Guides,” which the holder may reproduce at its expense.
- Title VI signs.

Publications necessary to maintain programmatic consistency are listed below, along with a URL address where they can be viewed and downloaded.

- “Cleaning Recreation Sites”
(Found at: https://www.fs.usda.gov/t-d/php/library_card.php?p_num=9523%201206)
- “In-Depth Design and Maintenance Manual for Vault Toilets” (Found at: https://www.fs.usda.gov/eng/php/library_card.php?p_num=9123%201601)
- “Vault Toilet Pumping Contract Specifications and Guidelines for Preparing Contracts.”
(Found at: https://www.fs.usda.gov/t-d/php/library_card.php?p_num=9223%201308)

F. Utilities and Waste Management

Certain utilities and infrastructure exist for the developed recreation sites identified in this prospectus. The permit holder will be responsible for securing, managing, and paying for these

utilities. Applicants should contact current service providers to obtain estimated costs for the utilities. These utilities include:

Electrical: The current electric provider is Clay Electric Coop, Inc., Salt Springs, Florida. The permit holder is required to contact the provider to make necessary transfer of service arrangements. Service will be in the name of the permit holder.

Telephone: The current telephone provider is Century Link, Ocala, FL. The permit holder is required to contact the provider to make necessary transfer of service arrangements. Current landline numbers must remain the same for the entrance station and concession store. Service will be in the name of the permit holder.

Water: Water at Salt Springs Campground and Day Use Area is provided by Marion County. The permit holder is required to operate and maintain the water system for the campground and day use area in compliance with applicable federal, state, and local laws and regulations for the operation and maintenance of a public drinking water system. The permit holder is not responsible for operation and maintenance of the wells that provide water to the community of Salt Springs that are located within the campground. These specific wells are maintained by Marion County Utilities.

Garbage: The current provider is GFL Environmental, Inc. The permit holder is responsible for removing all garbage from the area. All dumpsters are required to be bear resistant. Waste management providers are located within the local area. Permit Holder will be required to ensure all visitors and employees abide by the food storage order. Recycling is recommended.

Liquid/Solid Waste Disposal: The permit holder will be responsible for operation, inspection, maintenance, and upkeep of these systems to include drain fields, any lift or live systems, tank pumping, and pipe service and maintenance. The current provider is Marion County Utilities.

II. Forest Service Concession Programs and Policies

Government-owned concessions are authorized by special use permits issued under Section 7 of the Granger-Thye (GT) Act, 16 U.S.C. 580d, and implementing regulations at 36 CFR Part 251, Subpart B.

In addition, there are certain Forest Service programs and policies that apply to campground concession. All applications must be consistent with these requirements.

A. Recreation.gov

The National Forests in Florida, Ocala National Forest participates in Recreation.gov, which provides nationwide, toll-free telephone reservations for single-family or group camping sites, rental cabins, permits, tours, tickets, and other recreational facilities. Visitors pay the camping fee at the time they make a reservation, and no fees are collected at the site (although the permit holder may allow occupancy of any site that is unreserved and charge on site for that use).

Recreation.gov is part of the Recreation One-Stop Program, which is managed by the Washington Office Recreation, Heritage, and Volunteer Resources staff. The Forest Service

contacts and program managers for Recreation.gov are listed below. Applicants should not contact the Recreation.gov contractor directly.

Tiffany Williams
Region 8 Developed Recreation Program Manager;
Regional Fee Program Coordinator; Regional Accessibility Coordinator,
Mobile: 404-576-1024

Griffin Schireman
Forest Service Contracting Officer's Technical Representative (COTR)
Office: 541-910-1705

Recreation.gov is the only authorized reservation system for Forest Service-developed recreation sites, including but not limited to campgrounds, cabins, and group use areas. Applicants may recommend adding sites to or deleting sites from Recreation.gov or changing the number of sites that may be reserved, the minimum number of days per reservation, or the location of sites that may be reserved. The permit holder also may make these recommendations during the term of the permit. The authorized officer will decide whether to accept or reject the recommendations.

Under Recreation.gov, the following guidelines must be followed, unless there are compelling operational reasons:

1. For each developed recreation site included in Recreation.gov, at least 60 percent of the units must be available for reservations. The rest of the units may be occupied on a first-come, first-served basis.
 - Reservation windows vary by type of site and are as follows:
 - Individual campsites: from 240 days to 0-4 days prior to arrival date, depending on location.
2. When Recreation.gov is utilized, the permit holder is responsible for on-site administration and will be required to:
 - Obtain daily arrival reports (DARs) each morning by establishing at least one central facsimile location, email address, or other means of obtaining and distributing DARs.
 - Develop a system for posting reservations at the sites so other visitors know which units are reserved.
 - Post and hold reserved sites for 26 hours past the posted check-in time.
 - Ensure that the party with the reservation is the party using the site.
 - Resolve any disputes over the use of reserved sites by drop-in campers.
 - Verify that visitors hold a valid federal pass (listed below) before giving the discount on fees for those passes (*see* section II.B). Do not discount fees if a visitor cannot present a valid pass.

- Golden Age or Golden Access Passport.
- America the Beautiful–The National Parks and Federal Recreational Lands Senior Pass or Access Pass.
- Other passes as required by the authorized officer and described in this prospectus, such as local area passes.
- Develop inventory data for sites being added to Recreation.gov, and update data for sites including fees charged the public and temporary site closures. Submit data updates to Recreation.gov at least annually.
- Communicate to Recreation.gov any emergency closures or other relevant operational changes as they occur.
- Approve customer refunds as appropriate, and process them through Recreation.gov. Refund policies can be found at <https://www.recreation.gov/rules-reservation-policies>.

Because reservations can be made up to a year in advance for group sites and up to 240 days in advance for family sites, Recreation.gov is currently accepting reservations for the upcoming operating season. Fees received by Recreation.gov will be held by the Forest Service and distributed following issuance of a special use permit to the successful applicant. In the final year of the permit, fees will be held in the same manner until a new permit is issued. The permit holder will honor reservations made prior to issuance of the permit at the price in effect when the reservations were made. If funds are distributed prematurely for dates outside the permit term, a bill for collection will to be issued to the permit holder.

B. Pass Discounts

The permit holder must provide a 50 percent discount on recreation fees charged under REA at developed recreation sites covered by this prospectus to holders of Golden Age and Golden Access Passports, as well as holders of the Interagency Senior and Access Passes.

Specifically, holders of these passes are entitled to a 50 percent discount on the fee for a single campsite occupied by the pass holders. The pass holders are not entitled to a discount on the fee for a multiple-family campsite, cabin, or group use area or any additional campsites occupied by those accompanying the pass holders. The 50 percent campsite discount does not include utility, water, or any other hookup fees.

Any loss of fee revenue from honoring the passes should be factored into applicants' bids.

The permit holder will not be required to offer discounts on camping to holders of the Annual or Volunteer Pass.

The following is a list of sites covered by this prospectus where the 50 percent discount for passes applies:

- **Salt Springs Campground**
- **Salt Springs Day Use Area**

C. Camp Stamps

Camp stamps must be honored at their face value and submitted to the authorized officer for reimbursement.

D. Site Closure

The Forest Service reserves the right to close all or a portion of any area in this prospectus for repair; construction; floods, snow, extreme fire danger, or other natural events; wildlife protection; or risks to public health and safety. The Forest Service shall not be liable to the permit holder for lost revenue, operating costs, or any other losses resulting from these closures. However, for fee calculation purposes, the permit shall be placed in non-use status as provided by FSH 2709.11, section 31.23.

Site closures are expected for a short period for engineering assessments at Salt Springs Campground and Day Use area. Based on those assessments, site closures would be expected for any repairs or renovations at the day use area, and only certain areas within the campground would be closed at a time for repairs. The concessionaire will be notified in advance of expected closures.

E. Administrative Use

If the Forest Service requires the permit holder to provide a service for the agency, the permit holder will be compensated for that use.

F. Applicable Forest Orders

Forest Orders may be issued to address a variety of management concerns on a particular forest. Sample orders related to the offering are identified in Appendix 4. Additional applicable forest orders may be issued in the future.

G. Fee Tickets and Compilation of Use and Revenue Data

The permit holder must provide fee tickets to visitors that include at least the following information:

- The site number and total amount paid.
- The date of issuance and number of days paid for.
- If a pass is used, the pass number.
- The number of people in the group.
- The number of vehicles and their license plate numbers.

The permit holder must provide use and revenue data to the Forest Service (*see* Appendix 5 of the prospectus for a sample use report). Use reports must be completed monthly and at the end of the operating season for each developed recreation site, provided that when the holder performs GT fee offset work in lieu of paying the land use fee in cash, use reports may be submitted quarterly, rather than monthly. At a minimum, monthly and year-end use reports must include:

- Total recreation fee revenue.
- Total fee revenue for other goods and services.
- The total number of units occupied based on daily counts.
- The total number of people based on daily counts.
- The percentage of occupancy by month.
- The total number of Camp Stamps collected.
- The total number of passes used.

In addition, year-end use reports must include:

- Total fee revenue collected under the NRRS.
- Total taxes paid.
- Total gross revenue.
- Total net revenue.

H. Customer Service Comment Cards

The permit holder must provide a customer service comment mechanism for visitors at each developed recreation site covered by this prospectus (*see* Appendix 6 of the prospectus).

I. Performance Evaluations

At a minimum, the Forest Service will perform a year-end performance evaluation within four months of the close of the operating season (*see* Appendix 7 of the prospectus). An unsatisfactory rating may be cause for suspension or revocation of the special use permit. Sustained satisfactory performance is required for a permit extension.

J. Accessibility

The Architectural Barriers Act of 1968 (ABA) and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 require new or altered facilities to be accessible, with few exceptions. In 2004, the Architectural and Transportation Barriers Compliance Board (Access Board) issued revised accessibility guidelines for buildings and facilities subject to the ABA and the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). These new guidelines are called the ADA/ABA Accessibility Guidelines. In 2006, the Forest Service issued the Forest Service Outdoor Recreation Accessibility Guidelines (FSORAG). The FSORAG addresses types of recreational facilities, including developed recreation sites, that are not covered by ADA/ABA Accessibility Guidelines.

Any Government maintenance, reconditioning, renovation, or improvement (*see* section III.C) must meet ADA/ABA Accessibility Guidelines, where applicable, as well as the FSORAG.

The FSORAG and the ADA/ABA Accessibility Guidelines are posted on the Forest Service's website at <https://www.fs.usda.gov/recreation/programs/accessibility/>. Questions regarding ADA/ABA Accessibility Guidelines may be referred to the Access Board at www.access-board.gov. Questions regarding the FSORAG may be referred to the accessibility coordinator for the local National Forest.

The permit holder is responsible for ensuring effective communication with visitors with disabilities, including persons with impaired vision or hearing, so that all visitors may obtain information on accessible services, activities, and facilities.

K. Camping Unit Capacity

Number of Vehicles Per Camping Unit

A single-family camping unit may accommodate one vehicle. A "vehicle" is defined as any motorized conveyance, except that for purposes of vehicular capacity, two motorcycles are considered one vehicle. Additional vehicles may be allowed at a camping unit, if the camping unit can safely accommodate them. When extra vehicles are allowed, an extra fee of up to 50 percent of the camping unit fee may be charged for each extra vehicle. If an extra vehicle exceeds the camping unit capacity (i.e., the extra vehicle causes a safety hazard or resource damage), the customer may be required to pay for an additional camping unit or park in an overflow parking area, if available. One towed vehicle per single camping unit will be allowed for no extra charge if it can be parked completely on the surfaced area and does not create a safety hazard. Examples of towed vehicles include a boat trailer or a car towed by a motor home.

Camp Site Capacity

The maximum number of persons allowed is five per campsite.

Day Use Site Capacity

The maximum number of vehicles is 112.

L. Stay Limit

Campers at overnight sites will be limited to a 14-day stay limit during any consecutive 30-day period.

M. Fees Charged to the Public

The permit holder may charge the public fees only to the extent that the Forest Service can charge recreation fees under REA. All recreation fees must be specified per developed recreation site. The holder must honor the proposed pricing through the first full operating season. Thereafter, the holder may propose price adjustments with justification.

Permit holders may not charge for any of the following:

- Solely for parking, undesignated parking, or picnicking along roads or trail sides.
- General access, unless specifically authorized by REA.

- Dispersed areas with low or no investment, unless specifically authorized by REA.
- Persons who are driving through, walking through, boating through, horseback riding through, or hiking through NFS lands without using the recreational facilities and services for which a fee is charged.
- Camping at undeveloped sites that do not provide the minimum number of facilities and services prescribed by REA.
- Use of overlooks or scenic pullouts.
- Travel by private, noncommercial vehicle over any national parkway or any road or highway in the Federal-aid System that is commonly used by the public as a means of travel between two places, either or both of which are outside an area in which recreation fees are charged.
- Travel by private, noncommercial vehicle, boat, or aircraft over any road, highway, waterway, or airway to any land in which the person traveling has a property right, if the land is in an area in which recreation fees are charged.
- Any person who has a right of access for hunting or fishing privileges under a specific provision of law or treaty.
- Any person who is engaged in the conduct of official federal, state, tribal, or local government business.
- Special attention or extra services necessary to meet the needs of the disabled.

N. Law Enforcement

Forest Service Manual (FSM) 2342.1, Exhibit 01, addresses the law enforcement authorities and responsibilities of concessionaires, state and local law enforcement agencies, and the Forest Service at concession campgrounds. *See* Appendix 8 of the prospectus.

O. Other Pertinent Information

Cultural Resource Protection

The Permit Holder has responsibilities under the National Historic Preservation Act of 1966 (NHPA). The Permit Holder must notify the Forest Service and obtain Forest Service approval prior to any ground disturbance.

Salt Springs is a multi-component archaeological site comprised of shell middens, burial mounds, and habitation mounds. This significant historic site dates from the Late Paleoindian (11,000-6,000 B.C.) to St. Johns II period (A.D. 800-1500). The site is considered eligible for listing in the National Register and is protected by several federal and state laws including but not limited to; Section 106 of the National Historic Preservation Act of 1966, Code of Federal Regulations Title 43, Section 267, Florida Statutes, and Section 872 Florida Statutes.

Wildlife Mitigation

Permit holder should encourage guests to treat wildlife with respect and observe wildlife from a safe distance. The permit holder is responsible for assuring that employees of the holder do not store food or dispose of food outside of trailers or other enclosed living spaces, and that food is removed seasonally to prevent unwanted wildlife encounters, especially bears. Visitors and staff should be discouraged from approaching or feeding wildlife which includes scattering birdseed or hang birdfeeders, hummingbird feeders, as these may attract unwanted rodents, bees or ants. Salt licks are also not allowed. Food Storage is required per Forest Order 2009-01 (See Appendix 4). The permit holder is responsible for communicating requirements and expectations related to proper food storage and disposal to all employees of the holder and to guests. In the event of a significant wildlife interaction with the public, follow action plan as appropriate, for any emergency, call 911.

Alligators: Like all native wildlife, alligators are not to be fed or harassed. Nuisance alligators can be removed by a licensed trapper and that process is handled through the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (FWC) by calling 866-FWC-GATOR (866-392-4286). Not all alligators are nuisance alligators and they should not be reported unless they pose a true safety threat to visitors. Alligators are to be viewed from afar and not approached or chased off. If an alligator needs to be removed that task is left for the professionals.

Snakes: Florida is host to several species of water snakes and many other species that prefer aquatic environments.

Striped Bass: Striped bass will enter the spring area and remain for months. Having large concentrations of fish in a small area is stressful to the fish and concession personnel should avoid contributing to that stress. When striped bass are present in the spring they should not be disturbed if at all possible and should never be pursued. As visitation increases throughout the day the bass typically congregate in the spring vent or into the Salt Springs Run.

Black Bears: Because developed recreation sites are often located near water resources and recreation users bring food with them, developed sites have high potential for bear and human interactions. Therefore, responsibly run concessionaire sites are crucial to ensure public safety and to maintain the wild nature of the black bears and other species that inhabit the areas both within the recreation sites and across the Forest. Permit holder employees should have thorough knowledge of the current Food Storage Order (Order No. 2009-01) included in Appendix 4. All new employees should be trained on the Food Storage Order as part of job orientation. Damaged or non-functioning bear-proof trash containers should be replaced as soon as possible.

Wild Hog: Wild hog presence needs to be addressed quickly to prevent significant damage to the site. Permit holder will be responsible for contacting a qualified trapper for assessments, trapping, removal, and monitoring. A recommended but not required resource for hog removal is the USDA APHIS Wildlife Services Feral Swine Damage Management program. No firearms may be used on site other than by USDA APHIS personnel. Only live trapping can be employed in recreation sites.

Threatened and Endangered Species

This list is intended to inform interested parties of federal and state listed threatened and endangered species. The list includes but is not limited to documented species that are found at the site, and species that may occur at the site.

Recreation sites may provide habitat for the following federally listed threatened and endangered species: Florida Manatee, Tricolored Bat (endangered status pending), Florida Scrub-jay, Wood Stork, Everglades Snail Kite, Red-cockaded Woodpecker, Eastern Indigo Snake, Sand Skink, Monarch Butterfly (proposed threatened), Florida *Bonamia*, Scrub buckwheat, Britton's Bear Grass, Lewton's Polygala, Pigeon Wings, Pygmy Fringetree, Etonia Rosemary, Papery whitlow-wort.

Recreation sites may provide habitat for the following state listed threatened and endangered species: Gopher Tortoise, Short-tailed Snake, Florida Sandhill Crane, Little Blue Heron, Roseate Spoonbill, Tricolored Heron, Southeastern American Kestrel, Giant Orchid, Ocala Vetch, Pygmy Pipes, Narrowleaf Naiad, Scrub Stylisma.

State Protected Species: Bald Eagles

Endangered species are protected by Federal law, and State listed species are protected by State law. All actions proposed should be considered against these species and their habitat. Consultation with the Forest Service may be required to complete certain maintenance activities.

Condition of Trees

Salt Springs Recreation site sits within the flood plain of Salt Springs and Salt Springs Run. The overstory and understory is made up of mix of pines and variety of hardwoods grow in this area. Over time this site will fully transition to a Hardwood Hammock with species like (Water Oak, Laurel Oak, Live Oak, Sweetgum, etc.). Florida hardwoods develop rot naturally and as they grow bigger and older the risk of failure grows. Species like sand live oak does not develop rot as quickly, but the loss of soil to erosion and compaction could increase the chances of the roots giving away and whole tree falling over.

Hazard Tree Removal

The permit holder will have to conduct preseason inspection of the recreation sites in this offering to identify existing and potential hazards, including hazard trees. The permit holder also will be responsible for monitoring and identifying hazard trees during the operating season. After securing written approval from the authorized officer, the permit holder's financial responsibility for removing hazard trees and associated slash will not exceed 1% of gross revenue per year. The annual operating plan will address appropriate disposal of hazard trees and slash.

Butane and Propane Installations

For safety and regulatory reasons, the permit holder is not allowed to install or store bulk butane or propane.

III. Special Use Permit

In exercising the rights and privileges granted by the special use permit, the permit holder must comply with all present and future federal laws and regulations and all present and future state, county, and municipal laws, regulations, and other legal requirements that apply to the permit area, to the extent they do not conflict with federal law, regulation, or policy. The Forest Service assumes no responsibility for enforcing laws, regulations, and other legal requirements that fall under the jurisdiction of other governmental entities.

A. Permit Term

The permit term will be for up to 5 years, with an option to extend the term for up to an additional 5 years at the sole discretion of the authorized officer. The decision to extend the term will depend, in part, on sustained satisfactory performance of the permit holder. Upon expiration of the permit, continuation of the permitted activity will be at the sole discretion of the authorized officer and will be subject to a competitive offering. A new prospectus will be issued during the final year of the permit term.

If the decision to select a permit holder is appealed, a permit will not be issued until the appeal has been resolved, unless operation is needed during the appeal, in which case a permit with a term of one year or less may be issued.

B. Permit Holder Responsibilities

This section highlights the requirements of the special use permit, which is contained in Appendix 10 of the prospectus. Applicants are responsible for familiarizing themselves with all permit requirements that govern the operation covered by this prospectus.

Responsibility for Day-to-Day Activities

As a general rule, the holder will be required to conduct the day-to-day activities authorized by the permit. Some, but not all, of these activities may be conducted by someone other than the permit holder, but only with the prior written approval of the authorized officer. The permit holder will continue to be responsible for compliance with all the terms of the permit.

Permit Holder-Furnished Supplies and Equipment

The permit holder will be required to provide all vehicles, equipment, and supplies necessary to operate the authorized developed recreation sites in accordance with the special use permit.

Holder-Furnished Vehicles

The permit holder may not use all-terrain vehicles, motorcycles, or motor bicycles in the campgrounds. The holder may propose use of golf carts or other similar vehicles to facilitate daily maintenance of the facilities. If authorized, carts must stay on designated roads or trails while driving between sites or loops.

Holder Maintenance, Reconditioning, or Renovation (MRR)

Maintenance, reconditioning, and renovation are defined in the permit (FS-2700-4h, clause IV.E.1(a), (c)). Holder MRR is defined as maintenance, reconditioning, or renovation that neither materially adds to the value of the property nor appreciably prolongs its life. The work serves

only to keep the facility in an ordinary, efficient operating condition. From an accounting or tax perspective, it is work that may be expensed, but not capitalized. In fulfilling these responsibilities, the holder must obtain any licenses and certified inspections required by regulatory agencies and follow state and local laws, regulations, and ordinances and industry standards or codes applicable to the permitted operation (FS-2700-4h, clause IV.E.1(d)). The permit holder, at its expense, will be required to perform holder MRR under a holder MRR plan (FS-2700-4h, clause II.D). The holder MRR plan will describe required holder MRR and its frequency. The holder MRR plan will become part of the permit holder's annual operating plan.

C. Granger-Thye Fee Offset Agreement

The federal government owns all the improvements at the developed recreation sites covered by this prospectus. Under Section 7 of the Granger-Thye (GT) Act and the terms of the permit, the permit fee may be offset in whole or in part by the value of Government maintenance, reconditioning, renovation, and improvement (MRRI) performed at the permit holder's expense. Government MRRI is defined as maintenance, reconditioning, renovation, or improvement that arrests deterioration, improves and upgrades facilities, and appreciably prolongs the life of the property. Government maintenance, reconditioning, renovation or improvement, whether performed by the holder or the Forest Service, shall be performed at the sole discretion of the authorized officer. *See* Appendix 4 of the prospectus and FS-2700-4h, clause IV.E.

All Government MRRI shall be enumerated in an annual GT fee offset agreement signed by the holder and the Forest Service in advance of the operating season (*see* Appendix 11 of the prospectus and FS-2700-4h, Appendix B). Alternatively, a multi-year fee GT fee offset agreement can be prepared for consolidated fee payments. A list of sample Government MRRI projects is included in Appendix 12 of the prospectus.

The holder must perform GT fee offset work. When that work includes construction that costs more than \$2,000, it is subject to the Davis-Bacon Act and the GT fee offset agreement must contain Davis-Bacon Act wage provisions. Additionally, indirect costs may be offset provided the holder submits either a currently approved indirect cost rate or accounting procedures and supporting documentation to determine an indirect cost rate (*see* Appendix 13 of the prospectus).

The holder's claims for GT fee offset must be documented using the FS-2700-4h, Appendix G, Granger-Thye Fee Offset Certification Form (*see* Appendix 14 of the prospectus). This form requires the holder to itemize allowable costs incurred for an approved GT fee offset project and to certify the accuracy and completeness of claims.

D. Insurance

Liability Insurance

The successful applicant must have liability insurance covering losses associated with the use and occupancy authorized by the permit arising from personal injury or death and third-party property damage in the minimum amount of \$30,000 for injury or death to one person per occurrence; \$500,000 for injury or death to more than one person per occurrence; and \$1,000,000 for third-party property damage per occurrence, or in the minimum amount of \$1,000,000 as a combined single limit per occurrence. Insurance policies must name the United States as an additional insured (*see* Appendix 10 of the prospectus and FS-2400-4h, clause III.I).

Property Insurance

Property insurance will be required for specific improvements as listed in Appendix 3 in the amount of \$500,000 for replacement in kind of the insured property (*see* Appendix 3, Inventory of Government-Furnished Property).

IV. Application

A. Instructions for Submitting Applications

Applicants must submit an application for all developed recreation sites offered in this prospectus.

Forest Led Facility Tour

A facility tour led by the National Forests in Florida is tentatively scheduled for April 30, 2025. Interested parties must RSVP to Danela.head@usda.gov by March 31, 2025.

Applicants are strongly encouraged to visit the sites at least once before submitting an application (*see* Appendices 1 and 2, vicinity and area maps and maps of developed recreation sites).

The information in this prospectus is from generally reliable sources, but no warranty is made as to its accuracy. Each applicant is expected to make an independent assessment of the business opportunity offered in this prospectus.

All applications must be submitted to:

Ivan Green, Forest Supervisor
ATTN: Salt Springs Recreation Area Prospectus
325 John Knox Road, Suite F-210
Tallahassee, FL 32303-4160

Applications must be received by close of business (4:30 p.m. EST) on **May 15, 2025.**

Applicants must submit one (1) hard copy and one (1) electronic copy of their application package and supporting documents to the Forest Service contact listed above. The electronic copy must be provided on a flash drive. The electronic copy must be prepared in a Microsoft Office program or pdf that allows for copying and pasting of text and must separately address each evaluation criterion listed in the prospectus.

Applications will not be returned to applicants.

Please ensure that all requested information is submitted. Missing or incomplete information will result in a lower rating for the corresponding evaluation criteria.

Applications must be signed. The person signing for an entity must have authority to sign for that entity. Applicants must include their address, telephone number, facsimile number, and email address.

Corporations also must include:

- Evidence of incorporation and good standing.
- If reasonably obtainable, the name and address of each shareholder owning 3 percent or more of the corporation's shares and the number and percentage of any class of voting shares that each shareholder is authorized to vote.
- The name and address of each affiliate of the corporation.
- If an affiliate is controlled by the corporation, the number of shares and the percentage of any class of voting stock of the affiliate owned, directly or indirectly, by the corporation.
- If an affiliate controls the corporation, the number of shares and the percentage of any class of voting stock of the corporation owned, directly or indirectly, by the affiliate.

Partnerships, limited liability companies (LLCs), associations, or other unincorporated entities must submit a certified copy of the partnership agreement or other documentation establishing the entity or a certificate of good standing under the laws of the state where the entity is located.

Applicants should contact Danela Head at danela.head@usda.gov regarding any questions related to this prospectus. The deadline to submit questions regarding this prospectus is **April 4, 2025**.

B. General Terms, Qualifications, and Reservations

All applicants have an equal opportunity to apply. Except for members of Congress, Resident Commissioners, and current Forest Service employees, any individual or entity may apply.

The Forest Service does not guarantee a profitable operation. Rather, applicants are responsible for reviewing the prospectus and making their own determination concerning business viability.

The Forest Service will select the application that offers the best value to the Government. The Forest Service reserves the right to select the successful applicant based on a trade-off between the fee to the Government and technical merit.

The Forest Service is not obligated to accept the application with the highest return to the Government.

The Forest Service reserves the right to select the successful applicant based solely on the initial application, without oral or written discussions.

The Forest Service reserves the right to reject any or all applications and to rescind the prospectus at any time before a special use permit is issued.

Any oral statement made by a representative of the Forest Service shall not modify the requirements of this prospectus. If it is determined that an error or omission has been made or additional information is required, a written amendment will be sent to each person or entity receiving a copy of this prospectus.

If there is a conflict between the terms of the prospectus and the special use permit, the terms of the permit will control.

The Forest Service is proposing a revision to FSM 2344.3 to address how passes and passports are honored in the concession program. The agency reserves the right to amend the special use permit consistent with any change to that directive. In addition, the Forest Service reserves the right to amend the special use permit, to make it consistent with applicable laws and regulations, including REA; other Forest Service directives; or other management decisions.

The information contained in applications will be kept confidential to the extent permitted under the Freedom of Information Act (5 U.S.C. 552) and the Privacy Act (5 U.S.C. 552a).

C. Application Package Requirements

Applications must be in writing and must include or address the following:

- A proposed annual operating plan (including required and optional services).
- A business plan, business experience, references, and Small Business Development Center (SBDC) review fee, if applicable (*see* section IV.C.2).
- Financial resources.
- Fees charged to the public.
- Fee to the government.
- Fees.
 - Initial processing fee of **\$500.00** made payable to USDA Forest Service.
 - SBDC business plan review of **\$350.00** made payable to Alaska Small Business Development Center.

1. Proposed Annual Operating Plan (Including Required and Optional Services)

Applicants must submit a proposed annual operating plan that addresses all required and optional services. Applicants must utilize the sample annual operating plan (*see* Appendix 9 of the prospectus) to organize their response to this section. The successful applicant's proposed operating plan will be attached to and become a part of the special use permit.

Applicants must specify whether another party will assist with any of the operational aspects of the concession, and if so, must include the other party's name, address, telephone number, email address, and relevant experience.

Below are highlights of what needs to be addressed in the proposed annual operating plan. For more detail, see the sample annual operating plan in Appendix 9 of the prospectus.

Operating Season

Salt Springs Campground and Day Use Area is open year-round, unless a Forest Service closure order is in effect.

All sites must be open and operational seven days per week during the minimum operating season, unless a Forest Service closure order is in effect.

Staffing

Applicants must address appropriate staffing to meet customer service and cleanliness standards. The holder will be responsible for furnishing all personnel for the developed recreation sites and for adequately training and supervising their activities under the terms of the permit. The holder must meet requirements of federal and state laws governing employment, wages, and worker safety. Based on past experience, recommended staffing is outlined in Appendix 9 of the prospectus. Applicants should address worker hours and schedules. Applicants also should address staff training for effective customer service, conflict resolution, area-specific emergency procedures, and dissemination of recreation and tourism information.

Supervision and Management

Applicants must designate an individual to serve as the agent of the holder for purposes of administration of the permit by the Forest Service. The designated agent must periodically review attendant performance on site and must be available to resolve repair needs within 24 hours of discovery or notification. The holder will be responsible for the conduct of its employees, including preventing conduct prohibited by 36 CFR part 261, Subpart A, and ensuring that employees are not under the influence of intoxicating beverages or narcotic drugs while on duty or representing the holder. Applicants also must include a policy for removing employees who engage in inappropriate conduct.

Uniforms and Vehicle Identification

Applicants should describe employee uniforms, insignia, name tags, and the applicants' policy for ensuring a clean, professional appearance by staff while on duty. The holder's employees may not wear any component of the Forest Service uniform. Additionally, applicants should address their policy for vehicle maintenance and appearance; types of vehicles to be used for operations (vehicles may not be driven off designated roads or trails); and signage to identify the concessionaire to the public.

2. Business Plan, Business Experience, and References

Applicants must submit a business plan utilizing the format in Appendix 16 of the prospectus. This part of the application package must be a separate document. The business plan provides a thorough analysis of an applicant's vision of the proposed business. A good business plan is essential for running a successful business, maintaining and improving the business, and raising needed capital.

Applicants must furnish a detailed description of their experience relating to operating and maintaining developed recreation sites (e.g., campgrounds, beaches, and marinas). The description must include experience in private business, public service, or any nonprofit or other related enterprises. Applicants are encouraged to contact their local SBDC if they need assistance in completing their business plans. Alternatively, applicants who have already received a review of their business plan from an SBDC or the Forest Service for the current fiscal year may submit a copy of the review report.

SBDC Review

All business plans will be independently reviewed by an SBDC. Applicants are required to submit one (1) copy of their business plan. If an applicant's current fiscal year business plan has already been reviewed by an SBDC, the applicant may submit a copy of the review report.

Along with a business plan, applicants also must submit a bank draft, money order, or cashier's check in the amount of **\$350.00** made payable to the Alaska Small Business Development Center, 3211 Providence Drive, BOC 3, Suite 199, Anchorage, Alaska 99508. Applicants submitting a current fiscal year review report by the Forest Service or an SBDC need not enclose payment.

Performance Evaluations

Applicants who have experience in managing Forest Service or other Government concessions must provide copies of the most recent annual written performance evaluations for each Forest Service or other concession the applicants have operated or are operating.

References

Applicants also must furnish three business references with names, addresses, telephone numbers, and email addresses in support of relevant business experience. These references will be contacted for information regarding applicants past performance. In addition, the Forest Service may consider past performance information from other sources.

3. Financial Resources

Applicants must submit a complete set of all financial statements for the last three fiscal years that have been audited, reviewed, or compiled by a certified public accountant (CPA). For any financial statements that were only compiled by a CPA, applicants must complete FS-6500-24, Financial Statement (*see* Appendix 17 of the prospectus) for certification of the accuracy of the financial statements.

Applicants must complete FS-6500-24 for any of the last three fiscal years they were in business for which a financial statement was not audited, reviewed, or compiled by a CPA. An applicant who has had a financial ability determination (FAD) conducted within the past year should include a statement to that effect along with the forest name, contact name and telephone number. Additionally, applicants must identify any pending applications or new permits obtained from the Forest Service since the FAD was completed.

In completing FS-6500-24, LLCs must list the name of the company in block 1, the names and interests of the principals in block 5, and their members should be listed in block 6. In addition, LLCs must complete the certification in Part (D)(1) of FS-6500-24.

An applicant who has not been in business for the last three fiscal years, and therefore cannot submit audited, reviewed, or compiled financial statements or an FS-6500-24, must submit three fiscal years of projected financial statements compiled by a CPA using the forecast method.

Any financial information submitted by applicants must conform to generally accepted accounting principles (GAAP) or other comprehensive bases of accounting. Any previously prepared financial documents that are submitted must be unredacted and in their original form, including footnotes.

Previous edition obsolete

Applicants must show at least 25 percent of the first year's operating costs in liquid assets. Liquid assets are assets that are readily converted into cash.

Applicants also must complete blocks 1 through 5 of form FS-6500-25, Request for Verification (see Appendix 18 of the prospectus) and submit the signed and dated form with the application. The Forest Service will forward the FS-6500-25 for the most qualified applicant to the Albuquerque Service Center for processing. The auditor assigned to conduct the FAD will send a copy to each financial institution with which the applicant does business. The financial institutions must complete blocks 6 through 15 of the form and mail the completed form to USDA Forest Service, Albuquerque Service Center, Attention: Auditor, ASC-B&F, 101 B Sun Ave NE, Albuquerque, NM 87109.

4. Fees Charged to the Public

Applicants must provide a list of all fees they propose to charge to the public for the **first three years of operation, including fees for required and optional services** (see Appendix 9, Sample Annual Operating Plan, for a list of required and optional services). Discuss any variable pricing, discounts, and passes. All proposed fees to be charged to the public also must be included in the business plan as an income item.

The Forest Service reserves the right to regulate the rates charged to the public.

5. Fee to the Government

The Government is obligated to obtain fair market value for the use of its land and improvements. The minimum fee is **\$68,470** per year. The minimum fee is the concession's average gross revenue for the past three years multiplied by the current 30-year Treasury bond rate. The minimum fee will be adjusted at the end of the first five years of the permit term if the permit is extended for five years.

Minimum Fee Calculation

Year	Gross Revenue
2022	\$1,626,645.39
2023	\$1,734,132.62
2024	\$1,173,666.21
Grand Total	\$4,534,444.22
Average = Grand Total ÷ 3	\$4,534,444.22 ÷ 3
Three Year Average Gross Revenue	\$1,511,481.43

Total gross revenue ÷ 3 = average gross revenue

Average gross revenue multiplied by the current 30-year Treasury bond rate = the minimum annual fee. In the following example, the 30-year Treasury bond rate is 4.53 percent as of March 5, 2025.

$\$1,511,481.43 \times 0.0453 = \$68,470$ **minimum annual fee**

Previous edition obsolete

Applicants may propose a fee below the minimum, provided they can document why this amount represents fair market value. However, the Forest Service may reject the proposed fee if the agency determines that it does not reflect fair market value.

Applicants must propose the fee to the Government as a percentage of the concession's adjusted gross revenue. One percentage may be proposed for the entire permit term, or the percentage may vary each year. However, if a consolidated fee payment will be proposed, one percentage rate must be proposed for the entire period of consolidated payments.

The proposed fee to the Government also must be included in the business plan as an expense item in the cash flow projections.

The fee to the Government may be offset in whole or in part by the value of Government MRRI, performed at the permit holder's expense in accordance with a GT fee offset agreement (*see* section III of the prospectus).

6. Application Fee

Cost Recovery

Applications submitted in response to this prospectus are subject to cost recovery pursuant to 36 CFR 251.58(c)(1)(ii) and (c)(3)(iii). Applicants must submit a processing fee of **\$500.00** to cover the cost of the prospectus and review of the application. Payments due the United States for this application must be paid in the form of a bank draft, money order, or cashier's check payable to the USDA-Forest Service. Payments will be credited on the date received by the designated Forest Service collection officer or deposit location. Additionally, the selected applicant will be responsible for the costs of preparing and issuing the permit and conducting a FAD, unless the Forest Service has conducted a FAD for the applicant within the past year. If a FAD has been completed for the applicant within the last 12 months, the applicant will be responsible for the cost of adjusting it to reflect any change this selection will have on the applicant's financial ability.

D. Evaluation of Applications

A Forest Service evaluation panel will evaluate each application utilizing the non-fixed weight method.

Criterion 1 is more important than criterion 2, and both are more important than the other criterion.

The following evaluation criteria are listed in descending order of importance:

- Proposed annual operating plan (including required and optional services).
- Business plan, business experience, and references.
- Financial resources.
- Fee to the Government.
- Fees charged to the public.

The Forest Service will consider only the applicant's written application package and any past performance information obtained by the Forest Service. During the evaluation process, the evaluation panel may contact any references, including all federal, state, and local entities that have had a business relationship with the applicant. The evaluation panel also may consider past performance information from other sources.

The evaluation panel will provide an evaluation summary of applicant's ratings to the authorized officer. The authorized officer will make the selection decision based on which applicant offers the best overall value to the Government. All applicants will be notified of the successful applicant via certified mail.

The Forest Service will conduct a FAD on the selected applicant as a prerequisite to issuing a special use permit, unless the agency has a current fiscal year FAD conducted by the Albuquerque Service Center or SBDC for another Forest Service unit.

The Forest Service reserves the right to reject any and all applications.

The Forest Service reserves the right to rescind the prospectus at any time before a special use permit is issued. If the Forest Service rescinds the prospectus, application fees will be returned.

V. Post-Selection Requirements

Once an applicant has been selected, the following information must be submitted and approved by the Forest Service prior to issuance of a special use permit:

- A final annual operating plan containing all the items included in the annual operating plan submitted in response to the prospectus.
- An annual GT fee offset agreement.
- Documentation of required liability insurance and, if applicable, property insurance.
- Documentation of bonding, if applicable.
- Required deposits and advance payments (*see* Appendix 10 of the prospectus and FS-2700-4h, clause IV.C.1).
- Documentation that utility services have been obtained in the name of the selected applicant.
- A state business license and any other required federal, state, or local certifications or licenses.

The successful applicant will be required to submit all these items within 30 days of the date of the selection letter. If these requirements are not met within the 30-day period, a special use permit will not be issued. The applicant who receives the next-highest rating may then be selected for the special use permit, subject to the same requirements.

Burden and Non-Discrimination Statement

According to the Paperwork Reduction Act of 1995, an agency may not conduct or sponsor, and a person is not required to respond to a collection of information unless it displays a valid OMB control number. The valid OMB control number for this information collection is 0596-0082. The time required to complete this information collection is estimated to average 10 hour per response, including the time for reviewing instructions, searching existing data sources, gathering and maintaining the data needed, and completing and reviewing the collection of information.

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) prohibits discrimination in all its programs and activities on the basis of race, color, national origin, age, disability, and where applicable, sex, marital status, familial status, parental status, religion, sexual orientation, genetic information, political beliefs, reprisal, or because all or part of an individual's income is derived from any public assistance. (Not all prohibited bases apply to all programs.) Persons with disabilities who require alternative means for communication of program information (Braille, large print, audiotape, etc.) should contact USDA's TARGET Center at 202-720-2600 (voice and TDD).

To file a complaint of discrimination, write USDA, Director, Office of Civil Rights, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-9410, or call toll free at (866) 632-9992 (voice). TDD users can contact USDA through local relay or the Federal relay at (800) 877-8339 (TDD) or (866) 377-8642 (relay voice). USDA is an equal opportunity provider and employer. The Privacy Act of 1974 (5 U.S.C. 552a) and the Freedom of Information Act (5 U.S.C. 552) govern the confidentiality to be provided for information received by the Forest Service.